KPPSC PMS • EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER I) ## QUESTION 10: CAUSES OF THE FRENCH REVOLUTION & PHILOSOPHICAL MOTIVATIONS (1789)

EXECUTIVE EXAM METADATA - **EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED: 2018 Q.1: 'Critically examine the social, economic, and intellectual causes of the French Revolution of 1789.' 2016 Q.1: 'Discuss in detail the philosophy of Liberty, Equality, and Fraternity that motivated the French people to revolt against monarchical powers in 1789.' 2013 Q.1: 'The conditions in Europe were always the same except in England. But why did the revolution occur in France and not in any other country?' - **SYLLABUS TOPIC:** Paper I — Section 1: The French Revolution (1789–1799) — Causes, Social Dynamics & Philosophy - **ALLOCATED MARKS / TIME:** 20 Marks | 35 Minutes | Standard Word Count: ~650–700 words - **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL THESIS:** The French Revolution of 1789 was not the spontaneous eruption of sheer misery, but the structural implosion of an archaic, fiscally bankrupt feudal absolute monarchy colliding with an economically ascendant, literate bourgeoisie and an aggrieved peasantry, catalyzed by Enlightenment critique that delegitimized divine right and articulated the transformative revolutionary triad: 'Liberté, Égalité, Fraternité'.**

📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY > • The Three Estates Imbalance: 1st Estate (Clergy, 100k) & 2nd Estate (Nobility, 400k) owned 40% of fertile land and enjoyed total exemption from direct taxation (taille, corvée). The 3rd Estate (24 million peasants, artisans, bourgeois) paid over 70% of their net income in feudal, royal, and ecclesiastic dues. > > • De Tocqueville's Paradox ('Why France?'): Revolutions erupt not where oppression is absolute (Russia, Austria), but where expanding economic freedom and partial property ownership make surviving feudal burdens intolerable. French peasants owned land and the French bourgeoisie was intellectually mature, making feudal exclusions intolerable. > > • The Financial Death-Spiral: Participation in the American War of Independence (1778–1783) added 1.3 billion livres of debt. By 1788, 50% of the royal budget went strictly to debt service. When Calonne and Brienne attempted to tax the nobility, the aristocratic Parlements rebelled, forcing the convocation of the Estates-General. > > • The Philosophical Triad: Liberty (Montesquieu: freedom from arbitrary arrest and royal despotism; separation of powers), Equality (Rousseau: equality before law, abolition of aristocratic privilege), Fraternity (National brotherhood replacing regional and estate divisions into one sovereign Nation). >

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1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY ```

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STRUCTURAL PRESSURES INTELLECTUAL CATALYST TRIGGER & REVOLT (1789)

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[1st & 2nd Estates: Tax-Exempt] + [Montesquieu: Law & Liberty] --> [1788 Fiscal Bankruptcy] [3rd Estate: Borne 70% Taxes] + [Voltaire: Anti-Clericalism] --> [Estates-General (May 1789)] [Bourgeoisie Barred from Power] + [Rousseau: Popular Sovereignty]--> [Tennis Court Oath (June 20)] [Agrarian Distress: Hail 1788] + [Sieyès: 'What is 3rd Estate']--> [Storming of Bastille (July 14)] --> [August 4: Feudalism Dead] --> [Declaration of Rights (Aug 26)]

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2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES | Date / Year | Event / Action | Historical & Exam Significance | |---|---|---| | **1774 | Accession of Louis XVI | Inherits ballooning national debt; appoints reformist Turgot who is dismissed under court pressure. | | **1778–1783** | French Aid to American Revolution | Bankrupts the Royal Treasury; introduces French soldiers (Lafayette) to republican ideology. | | **Feb 1787** | Assembly of Notables | Calonne's proposed universal land tax rejected by nobles; aristocratic resistance paralyzes monarchy. | | **Aug 1788** | Royal Bankruptcy Declared | Necker recalled; Louis XVI forced to summon the Estates-General for the first time since 1614. | | **Jan 1789** | Abbé Sieyès' Pamphlet | Publishes 'What is the Third Estate?': 'Everything. What has it been? Nothing. What does it ask? To become something.' | | **May 5, 1789** | Estates-General Convenes | Deadlock over voting by order (giving 2% nobles/clergy majority) vs. voting by head (Third Estate). | | **June 20, 1789** | Tennis Court Oath | Third Estate declares itself National Assembly; pledges not to disband until France has a written constitution. | | **July 14, 1789** | Storming of the Bastille | Parisian populace enters political arena; destroys royal fortress; saves Assembly from military coup. | | **Aug 4, 1789** | Night of August 4 | National Assembly formally abolishes feudalism, tithes, seigneurial dues, and aristocratic tax exemptions. | | **Aug 26, 1789** | Declaration of Rights of Man | Promulgates 'Liberty, Equality, Fraternity'; declares men born free and equal in rights; law as expression of General Will. |**

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3. THE 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (~650 WORDS)

Introduction: The Anatomy of a Revolutionary Breakdown The French Revolution of 1789 was the defining crucible of modern European civilization, radically fracturing the millennial edifice of feudal absolutism and ushering in the era of popular sovereignty, civic egalitarianism, and secular constitutionalism. In the historiographical debate, while classic Marxist scholars such as Georges Lefebvre and Albert Soboul interpreted 1789 as an inevitable class rupture wherein an economically emergent bourgeoisie smashed an outmoded feudal order, modern revisionists like François Furet and Alfred Cobban emphasize an institutional and cultural breakdown precipitated by fiscal collapse. In reality, the Revolution was an overdetermined phenomenon: an obsolete sociopolitical architecture (the Ancien Régime) paralyzed by structural privilege and fiscal bankruptcy collided with an agrarian subsistence crisis and a revolutionary philosophical discourse. Crucially, the revolutionary battle cry of 'Liberté, Égalité, Fraternité' did not merely reflect reactive discontent; it provided the transformative conceptual grammar that converted fiscal breakdown into a systemic ideological reconstruction of European political order.

Socioeconomic Structure: The Ancien Régime and the Estates Gridlock The fundamental structural vulnerability of 18th-century France lay in its rigid, tri-cameral estate system. The First Estate (the Catholic Clergy, numbering approximately 100,000) and the Second Estate (the Nobility, around 400,000) collectively monopolized over forty percent of France's agricultural land, controlled all high military and judicial offices, and enjoyed near-total exemption from direct taxation, notably the taille and corvée. In stark contrast, the Third Estate—comprising over 98 percent of the population (24 million souls)—bore the overwhelming fiscal burden of the state. Peasants, who constituted 80 percent of the populace, were crushed beneath a crushing tax pyramid of royal levies (taille, capitation, vingtième), feudal dues (banalités, champart), and the church tithe (dîme), often surrendering upwards of 70 percent of their harvest. Concurrently, the urban bourgeoisie—merchants, bankers, jurists, and intellectuals—experienced an acute status inconsistency: possessing burgeoning wealth and administrative expertise, they found themselves systematically excluded from political power by aristocratic monopolies, fueling deep structural resentment.

Fiscal Bankruptcy and Institutional Paralysis: The Immediate Trigger The proximate catalyst of 1789 was not general economic poverty, but the acute insolvency of the French Crown. France's extensive military expenditures during the Seven Years' War (1756–1763) and its decisive maritime and financial intervention in the American Revolutionary War (1778–1783)—financed predominantly through loans arranged by Jacques Necker—doubled the national debt to over four billion livres. By 1788, sovereign debt servicing alone consumed over fifty percent of annual state revenue. When Controllers-General Calonne and Brienne recognized that solvency required abolishing noble tax exemptions through a universal land tax, the aristocratic Parlements and the 1787 Assembly of Notables adamantly refused. By asserting that only an Estates-General could approve new taxes, the nobility initiated what Lefebvre termed the 'aristocratic revolt.' However, by paralyzing the crown, the nobility unwittingly opened the floodgates to popular mobilization. The catastrophic harvest of 1788, marked by devastating hail storms, doubled bread prices across Paris, creating an explosive convergence of urban starvation and elite institutional impasse.

The Intellectual Catalyst: Philosophers and the Triad of Liberty, Equality, Fraternity The Enlightenment provided the indispensable intellectual armory that transformed localized grievances into a coherent revolutionary ideology. While philosophers like Voltaire, Montesquieu, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau were not active conspirators of rebellion, their writings corroded the ideological legitimacy of divine right absolutism. Baron de Montesquieu's 'Spirit of the Laws' (1748) established the imperative of constitutional limits and the separation of executive, legislative, and judicial powers to safeguard 'Liberty' from royal despotism. Voltaire deployed corrosive satire to expose ecclesiastical corruption, religious intolerance, and legal brutality, fostering an intellectual climate of secular rationalism. Most decisively, Rousseau's 'Social Contract' (1762) introduced the revolutionary concepts of 'Popular Sovereignty' and the 'General Will,' arguing that legitimate political authority resides exclusively in the collective will of the sovereign citizenry, not in the dynastic person of the monarch. This philosophy was encapsulated in the immortal revolutionary triad: 'Liberté' represented the eradication of arbitrary arrest (lettres de cachet) and freedom of expression; 'Égalité' meant civic equality before the law and the abolition of aristocratic tax immunities; and 'Fraternité' forged a unified national brotherhood, superseding regionalism and corporate estates into an indivisible French Nation.

Tocqueville's Paradox: Why Did Revolution Erupt in France and Not Elsewhere? A pivotal comparative question in European history is why the revolutionary upheaval occurred in France rather than in Austria, Prussia, or Russia, where monarchical absolutism was far more despotic and peasant serfdom markedly harsher. As Alexis de Tocqueville perceptively demonstrated in 'The Old Regime and the Revolution' (1856), social revolutions break out not where conditions are objectively worst, but where partial progress and expanding prosperity make remaining feudal anachronisms appear profoundly intolerable. Unlike Russian or Prussian serfs who remained tied to the soil under unmitigated baronial servitude, French peasants were already legally emancipated landholders owning nearly half of the kingdom's soil; consequently, feudal tithes and seigneurial dues felt like arbitrary, parasitial extortions rather than

normal life. Similarly, the French bourgeoisie was the most affluent, educated, and self-conscious in continental Europe. Encountering an entrenched noble 'aristocratic reaction' that closed military officer ranks and magistrate posts via the Ségur Ordinance of 1781, the French middle class possessed both the economic leverage and ideological confidence to dismantle the state rather than endure subjugation.

Conclusion: The Enduring Legacy of 1789 In conclusion, the French Revolution was the result of a catastrophic confluence: an unsustainable structural inequality of estates, an acute fiscal bankruptcy brought on by imperial warfare, an agrarian bread crisis, and an Enlightenment intellectual renaissance that furnished the masses and bourgeoisie with an alternative moral architecture. When the Third Estate reconstituted itself as the National Assembly on June 17, 1789, followed by the storming of the Bastille on July 14, the streets and the legislature combined to dismantle absolute monarchy. In promulgating the Declaration of the Rights of Man on August 26, 1789, France did not merely reform its own borders; it established a universalist political template. By enthroning 'Liberty, Equality, and Fraternity' as the foundational metrics of legitimate governance, 1789 irrevocably dismantled the dynastic legitimacy of Europe and laid the ideological groundwork for modern democracy, human rights, and constitutional government.

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4. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES & SCHOLARLY QUOTES | Historian | Analytical Perspective | Exact Quotable Argument | |---|---|---| | **Alexis de Tocqueville | Institutional Continuity & Rising Expectations | 'The regime which is destroyed by a revolution is almost always an improvement on its immediate predecessor... Evils which are patiently endured when they seem inevitable become intolerable once the idea of escape from them is suggested.' | | **Georges Lefebvre** | Marxist Synthesis of Four Revolutions | 'The ultimate cause of the French Revolution was the rise of the bourgeoisie... but it was the aristocracy which opened the way by revolting against the monarchy, followed by the urban revolution and the agrarian revolt.' | | **François Furet** | Revisionist Political-Culture Critique | 'The French Revolution was not a transition from feudalism to capitalism, but the invention of a new political culture founded on the absolute, democratic legitimacy of the sovereign Nation.' | | **Abbé Sieyès (1789)** | Revolutionary Manifestation of Third Estate | 'What is the Third Estate? Everything. What has it been heretofore in the political order? Nothing. What does it demand? To become something.' |**
